crossing of two streets, Second Street and Third Street, which ‘cross each other just in front of this building’, the building, Dani believes, ‘served some special purpose’.[42] The frontage on the eastern side, adjacent to the Second Street, is semi-octagonal, with a ring of rooms on its inner side. The arrangement of these rooms, as also the square rooms on the western side, he says, shows an administrative purpose. The weakness of the inference, as in Marshall’s interpretation of rooms being used for ‘sleeping’ and ‘living’, lies in the fact that it is entirely extrapolated from the alignment of the rooms and not based on paraphernalia associated with city administration.

The paraphernalia of commerce, though, is more visible than that of administration. We have seen that the seals were likely to have formed part of the repertoire of merchants and traders. Made out of copper, glass, clay, and stone, the Taxilan seals are either pyramidical or scaraboid. The pyramidical shape was very popular at this time, being used not only for seals but also for delicate carnelian and agate pendants. Such seals are considered typically Mauryan and were usually very small. Why they were engraved with human figures remains unknown. In one instance, the presence of a staff, a circle, and the ‘nandipada’ (bull’s hoof) to the left of a standing man suggests that it could well represent a deity,[43] the bull being much worshipped in ancient India. The nandipada symbol also occurs on a terracotta sealing—the stamp being the impression made by the seal.[44] This sealing has the figure of a humped bull on both sides with the nandipada symbol above the hump. Yet another pyramidical seal, made of copper, has engraved on its base a ‘lotus-tree of life’, a symbol much used on early Buddhist monuments.[45]

The scaraboid seals, on the other hand, are thought to be of Western workmanship. So called because their shapes resemble the scarabaeid beetle, these were fairly popular in Persia. Their workmanship in Taxila is sometimes described as Greek—as, for instance, in the case of a black agate scaraboid with a lion’s back, and a chalcedony specimen with two winged